



PREGNANCY TESTS

How They Work and When to Take One

A pregnancy test is used to determine whether someone is pregnant. These tests detect a hormone called human chorionic gonadotropin, or hCG, which the body produces after a fertilized egg attaches to the uterus.

As early pregnancy develops, the amount of hCG in the body increases. Pregnancy tests detect this hormone in urine or blood to confirm whether pregnancy has begun.

Types of Pregnancy Tests

Urine Tests

- Used at home
- Detect hCG in urine
- Widely available and easy to use
- About 99% accurate when used correctly

Blood Tests

- Done at a healthcare provider's office
- Detect hCG in blood
- Can measure exact hormone levels
- Sometimes detect pregnancy earlier than urine tests

When to Take a Pregnancy Test

Some tests can detect hCG about 10 days after conception, but for the most accurate results, it is best to test after a missed period.

Using first morning urine may improve accuracy because hCG levels are more concentrated.

How Pregnancy Tests Work

Pregnancy tests detect hCG through a chemical reaction on a test strip.

Results may appear as:

- A plus sign
- Two lines
- The word “pregnant”

Most tests also include a control line or symbol to show the test is working.

Can Pregnancy Tests Be Wrong?

False negative

- Can happen if the test is taken too early

False positive

- Rare, but may happen after a very early pregnancy loss
- May also occur with certain fertility medications

What to Do After a Positive Test

- Schedule an appointment with a healthcare provider
- Begin taking prenatal vitamins with folic acid
- Avoid alcohol and smoking
- Follow healthy lifestyle habits

Key Takeaway

Pregnancy tests work by detecting hCG, which appears in the body after implantation. Home pregnancy tests are easy to use and highly accurate when taken after a missed period.

Bloom provides educational guidance only. Always consult with a qualified healthcare professional for personalized medical advice.

Educational content informed by Cleveland Clinic. Pregnancy Tests.